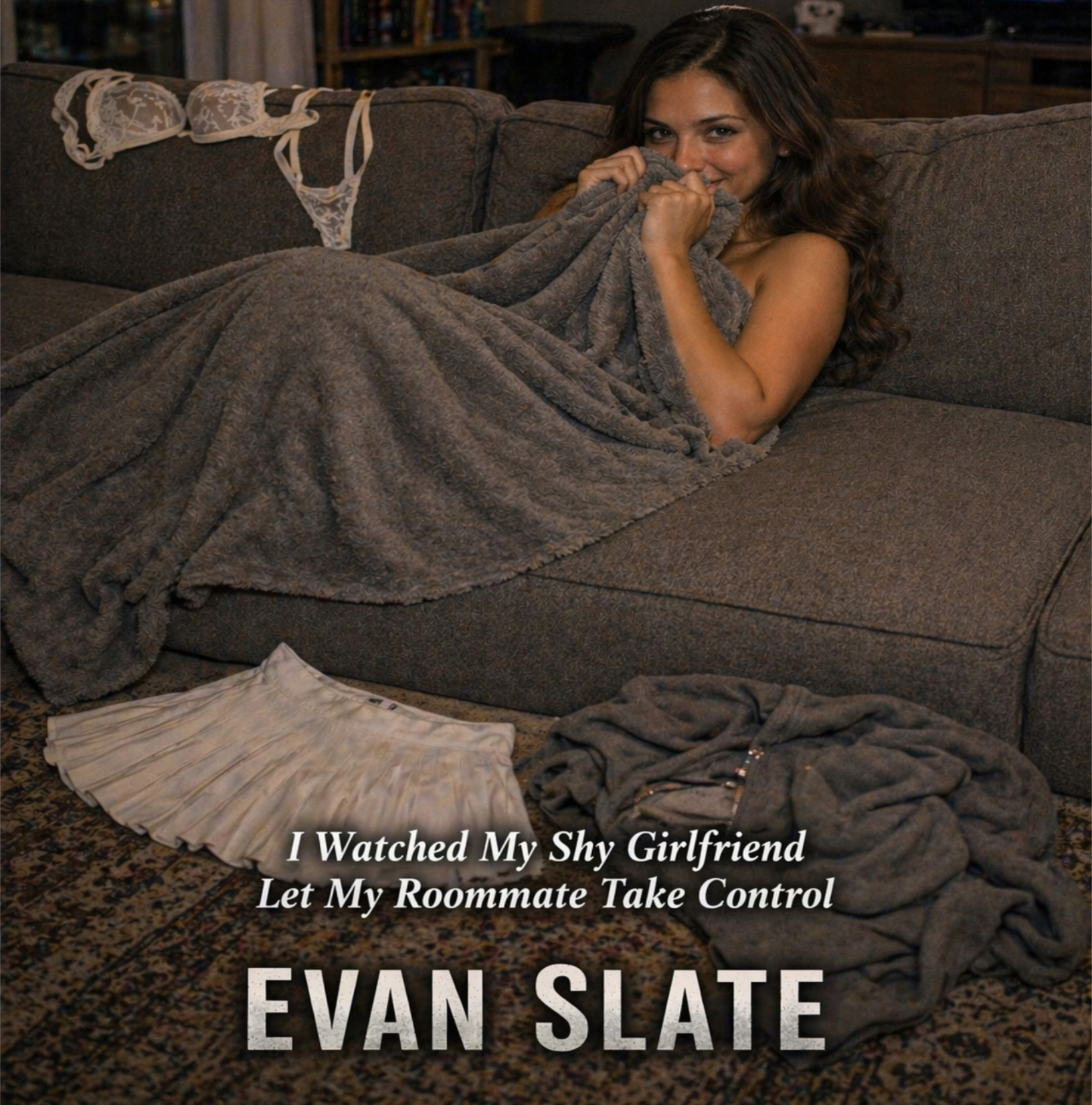


SHE WAS SO SHY AT FIRST



*I Watched My Shy Girlfriend
Let My Roommate Take Control*

EVAN SLATE

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I watched my shy girlfriend let my
roommate take control

Evan Slate

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Lila showed up around seven on Friday with her overnight bag and that shy smile she has when she's happy to see me, the one where she ducks her head and her hair falls forward over a shoulder. I was in the kitchen trying to remember if you're supposed to salt the water before or after it boils, and when I heard her knock I left the pot and went to let her in.

She was wearing high-waisted jeans and a cream cardigan over a white t-shirt, her hair in a long braid down her back. When she came inside she set her bag by the stairs and stood in the entryway like she was waiting for approval to go further into the house even though she'd been there a dozen times.

"Hey," I said, and I kissed her. She kissed me back soft and brief before pulling away and asking if she could help with dinner.

The house was old, a rental split between four of us, the kind of place with uneven floors and windows that didn't close and a persistent draft that made Lila cold whenever she stayed over. It had four bedrooms upstairs, one bathroom we all shared, and downstairs a living room with a sectional couch that sagged in the middle and a big screen we'd gotten secondhand from someone's older brother. The kitchen was small and narrow, barely room for two people without bumping into each other.

Lila moved around the kitchen gracefully, opening the fridge to get out the salad stuff she'd bought earlier in the week, apologizing when she bumped the counter with her hip even though nobody was around to bump into. She was like that, always apologizing for taking up space, always making herself smaller than she needed to.

I got the pasta going and she made the salad and we worked in comfortable silence, the kind we'd gotten good at over the eight months we'd been together. I felt good about the domestic routine of it, about her being here in my place doing normal couple things with me. It was what we both called a good relationship.

Tyler and Jason were both gone, the way they usually were on weekends. Tyler was pre-med and basically lived at the library, and Jason had a serious girlfriend across town and slept there most nights. It was usually just me and Marc in the house, which was fine. Marc was easy to live with, clean enough, and a lot of fun. I liked him, if in small doses.

He came home around eight, back from the gym, his hair still damp and his gym bag slung over a shoulder. He stopped in the kitchen doorway and said hey to both of us before dropping his bag by the stairs and coming back to lean against the counter.

"Smells good," he said, nodding at the pot on the stove. I said it was just pasta, nothing fancy. "Pasta is always good," he said.

Lila was at the counter tearing lettuce into a bowl. She glanced up at Marc and smiled quickly before looking back down at what she was doing, her face going pink the way it always did when someone she didn't know well talked to her.

"How's the semester going?" Marc asked her, probably knowing she was shy around guys like him. She said fine all quiet like, and he said, "You're English, right?" and she nodded. He asked what she liked reading and she said "Modernists mostly, Joyce and Woolf," and he made a face and said he'd tried Ulysses once and gave up after five pages.

That made her smile, a real one too. I knew she was impressed he even knew the name Joyce, let alone that he would be called a modernist. "Most people don't even try," she said, and he laughed and said he was persistent. She asked if he liked reading fiction, saying most guys didn't, and she glanced at me.

Marc glanced at me too. "I used to, before college made it feel like homework."

"I know what you mean, but I still love it anyway," she said, and I watched them talk some more and I felt good that Lila was opening up a little, that she wasn't doing the thing where she got too shy to speak at all. Marc wasn't the easiest type of person for a total introvert like Lila.

I invited Marc to join us and we ate at the small table in the kitchen, just the three of us crowded around it with our knees bumping underneath. The conversation kept going, Marc asking Lila questions about her classes and her professors, and actually listening to the answers and asking follow-up questions that made her elaborate. I secretly enjoyed watching her get more comfortable with him as the meal went on, her voice less quiet, her hands

gesturing more when she explained something about Virginia Woolf's narrative structure. She normally would have been a clam, or would have taken her bowl to our room, around a guy like him. Maybe she was ready to start changing.

After we cleaned up we moved to the living room and put on a movie, something I'd picked that none of us had seen. Lila and I took one end of the sectional, her tucked against my side with my arm around her, and Marc took the other end, sprawled out like he does with his feet up on the coffee table. The only light in the room came from the TV and the lone lamp in the corner.

The movie was fine, something with a lot of car chases that didn't require much attention, and halfway through, Lila shifted closer to me and put her head on my shoulder. I felt the weight of her and the warmth of her body against mine and thought about how much I liked this, the easy comfortable routine of Friday nights with her against me. It was safe and easy.

But I also liked how she got more expressive with Marc over dinner in the kitchen, and even more, chatting amiably here and there during the movie. It was good to see.

Around eleven Marc's phone buzzed and he checked it and said he was meeting some people out. He got up and grabbed his coat and said goodnight and headed out the door, and then it was just the two of us in the dim living room with the movie still playing.

"Imagine going out now, at bedtime!" Lila said with wide eyes.

"Imagine," I said, chuckling too.

We watched for another twenty minutes before Lila said she was tired, and I turned off the TV and we went upstairs to my room, the smallest of the four bedrooms, barely big enough for the twin bed and the desk and the dresser shoved against the wall. Lila set her bag on the floor and pulled out the t-shirt she slept in and I turned away while she changed, the way she preferred, and then I changed and turned off the light and we got into the narrow bed together.

She curled up against me in the dark, her back to my chest, and I put my arm around her waist and pulled her closer and kissed the back of her neck. She made a small sound and turned over to face me and we kissed, slow and gently. My hand slid up under her shirt to her bare skin and she let me go there this time, her breathing changing nearly imperceptibly.

We had sex the way we usually had sex, quiet and careful so as not to hurt her, me on top and her arms around my back, both of us trying not to make the bed creak too much because the walls were thin and Marc's room was right next door. He wasn't home, but still. Making noise wasn't like us.

She was responsive but reserved, her eyes closed even though the lights were out, and her face was turned to the side. She made small soft sounds that might have been pleasure or might have just been acknowledgment.

When we finished she went to the bathroom down the hall and came back and got back into bed and curled up facing away from me. I lay behind her with my arm around her waist and listened to her breathing as she fell asleep. I felt content, felt like this was good, felt like we were good, I felt like Friday nights like this were exactly what we both wanted and liked most.

A normal evening, a normal night, the kind we'd had dozens of times before and would have dozens of times again, or so I hoped. I fell asleep thinking about breakfast in the mornin with her, about the whole weekend stretched out ahead of us, about how lucky I was to have this serenity with my one and only quiet, passive, and sweet Lila. Things were perfect just the way they were.

Saturday we didn't have plans, which was fine with me. Lila and I spent the afternoon walking around campus and getting coffee, and by the time we got back to the house around six it was getting dark and cold and neither of us felt like going back out. Tyler was at the library studying for something, the way he always was, and Jason had texted the house group chat that he was staying at his girlfriend's place, so it was just me and Lila and Marc again.

We made sandwiches for dinner and ate them in the living room with the TV on, some cooking competition show none of us were really watching, and afterward we just stayed on the sectional, me and Lila on one end with her legs tucked up under her and Marc on the other end with his feet on the coffee table. The evening stretched out in that easy directionless way weekends do when you don't have anywhere to be.

At some point Marc started telling a story about his gap year, the year between high school and college when he'd gone to Europe and worked odd jobs and stayed in hostels, and Lila sat up and asked questions, actually engaged in a way I didn't see from her often with people. He told her about getting lost in Prague and ending up at some underground bar where

nobody spoke English and he'd had to mime his way through ordering a beer, and she laughed a real laugh that made her cover her mouth like she was surprised at herself as much as I was.

I watched her while Marc talked, watched the way she leaned forward when he got to the good part of a story, the way her face got more animated than it usually was, and I felt something small and uncertain but pushed it away because it was nothing, it was just her getting comfortable, being social more, and I realized I should be glad she was relaxed enough to be herself.

The conversation kept drifting, Marc asking Lila about where she'd grown up and what made her want to study English, and she asked him about economics and whether he actually liked it or was just doing it because it seemed practical. He laughed and said honestly probably the second one. She said that was sad and he should study something he cared about.

"Maybe in another life," he said. "I'll be your professor."

It got late without any of us noticing, the TV cycling through shows on autoplay, and at some point past midnight Lila shivered and said she was freezing. I got up and grabbed the blanket from the back of the couch and handed it to her, and she unfolded it and draped it over both of us, tucking it around her legs and pulling it up to her chin. Normally she'd want to go to bed, but not tonight.

Marc was talking about hostels again, some story about a guy he'd met in Barcelona who claimed to be a prince from a country that didn't exist anymore, and Lila was laughing and shaking her head. Marc said something about how she probably thought all his stories were made up, and she said no one could believe him, they sounded like a movie.

"Your life is probably way more interesting than his and you just don't realize it," he said.

"My life is extremely boring," Lila said, smiling. "Which is perfect."

"I don't believe that," Marc said.

"It's true. I go to class and I read books and I come over here on weekends. That's all I want."

"You make it sound so great."

"I'm not complaining, I'm just saying it's boring, but I like it that way."

"Boring's overrated," Marc said, and then he said something about how she seemed like the kind of person who had a secret interesting hobby, like

maybe she was really good at pottery or spoke four languages or something. She laughed and threw one of the couch pillows at him.

He caught it easy, grinning, and tossed it back at her. She caught it against her chest and set it down next to her, still smiling, her face flushed pink in a way that might have been from laughing or might have been from something else.

That was the first real playful moment between them, the pillow throw. It felt small and harmless and I didn't think much of it, just smiled and watched them and felt glad that Lila was comfortable enough to joke around. It looked good on her.

The conversation kept flowing, the three of us trading stories and questions, but I mostly I just listened and watched and felt the pleasant tiredness come on of staying up too late without anywhere to be the next morning. At one point I looked at my phone to see it was almost two, and I said something about how we should probably go to bed, but Lila looked surprised and said she didn't realize it was that late.

Marc stood and stretched and said goodnight and headed upstairs to his room and Lila folded the blanket and set it back on the couch. We turned off the TV and the lamp and went upstairs in the dark, careful on the creaky steps.

In my room Lila changed into her sleep shirt and I turned off the light and we got into bed. I expected her to be too tired, to curl up and fall asleep the way she usually did, but instead she turned to me and kissed me with more purpose than usual, her hand on my chest, but then sliding down. She laughed a little, and curled her shoulders up.

We had sex and it was different, not dramatically so, but noticeably. She was more present in it, more responsive with it, made sounds that were a little louder than her usual quiet breathing, and moved her hips in a way that seemed less self-conscious. I was surprised because we both knew that Marc was on the other side of the wall and probably not sleeping yet.

When we finished she pressed her face into my shoulder and her breathing took longer to slow down than it normally did. When she finally rolled over and settled into her usual sleeping position I lay behind her trying to figure out if I'd only imagined the difference.

I thought about the evening, about her laughing at Marc's stories, about the way she'd seemed more awake and alive than I usually knew her. I thought about the way she'd just been in bed, too, and I tried to connect

those things, but then told myself I was being stupid, that she was just in a good mood, that people had good days and bad and this was just a good day, and it didn't mean anything beyond that.

But I lay in the dark for a longer time before I fell asleep, listening to her breathe, and the question stayed in the back of my mind whether I wanted it or not.

The next weekend Lila came over Friday night and we fell into the same pattern without planning it, dinner and then the living room with the TV on low, the three of us settling in for another long night of talking more than watching whatever was playing on the screen.

Tyler was gone again, spending the weekend at his parents' place, and Jason had texted that he wouldn't be back until Sunday, so it was just us three in the house the way it had been the weekend before. When we moved to the living room after eating I expected we'd sit the same way we had then, Lila and me on one end of the sectional and Marc on the other.

But Marc sat down first this time, right in the middle section of the couch, and when Lila came in from the kitchen she paused for just a second, looking at the available spots, and then sat down next to him, on his right, leaving the far end of the sectional open.

I took the open end and sat down and told myself it was just where there was space, that it didn't mean anything, that the sectional was a sectional and people sat where they sat, but I felt the shift in geometry, felt the difference with Lila being next to Marc with me separate, and I didn't know how to say anything about it without sounding partially insane. I'm the only person I know who notices things like that.

What would I even say? You can't sit there? Sit next to me instead? It would sound controlling and weird like I didn't trust her, and I did trust her, I trusted both of them. So I sat on my end and pulled my phone out to check it and put it away and tried to focus on the show.

Lila was wearing leggings and an oversized sweater, her hair down around her shoulders, and after maybe twenty minutes she pulled the blanket off the back of the couch and unfolded it and draped it over herself, tucking it around her legs. Cold again.

"Hey, you took the whole thing," Marc said, grinning at her. She looked down at the blanket and then at him and her face went pink.

"Sorry," she said quietly, starting to pull it back off.

"I'm just messing with you," he said, laughing. "Can I share it though? It is kind of cold in here."

She hesitated for just a second and then nodded, that shy smile she made when she was pleased about something but trying not to show it, and she adjusted the blanket so it covered both of them. Now they were under the same blanket and I was separate and under nothing, just sitting on my end of the couch watching this. But it was fine, it was just Marc and my girlfriend, and we were all hanging out.

The mind does crazy things though. Under the blanket I could imagine their legs close together, maybe even touching, probably not, knowing Lila, but I felt something tighten in me.

The show was playing some action movie that none of us were paying much attention to, and Marc was telling another of his great stories, this one about a roommate he'd had freshman year who used to sleepwalk and woke up once in the campus fountain. Lila was listening with her whole body turned to him, her face lit up in that way it got when she was really engaged with what someone was saying. It was like she was seeing it in real time, hanging on every word.

At one point Marc adjusted how he was sitting, and I saw Lila react with just a small intake of breath and a barely noticeable tensing of her shoulders, like maybe their knees had bumped under the blanket. She didn't move away, though, and neither did he. They just stayed with whatever contact had been made under the blanket where I couldn't see, and my hands gripped my own knees. I made myself relax and paid attention to the show instead.

Marc said something funny that I didn't catch what, and Lila laughed really hard, the kind of laugh that took over her whole body, and she leaned into him, too, her shoulder falling against his shoulder. The moment lasted maybe two seconds before she seemed to catch herself and pulled back, straightening up, her face flushed now.

I watched the whole thing, the lean, the contact, the pull back. I sat on my end of the couch with my stomach knotting and my mind telling me it was nothing, it was just laughing, it didn't mean anything. It was just unusual for her, that's all. It was unexpected. She was just warming up to Marc in a way I hadn't really seen in her before.

The conversation kept going but I felt outside of it somehow, like I was watching the two of them talk and I was just in the room, present but not

part of what was between them.

We stayed up until past two again, the same as the weekend before, and when we finally went upstairs, I expected Lila to be way past tired, to change and get into bed and fall asleep right away.

But she didn't.

She changed into her sleep shirt and came to bed and turned toward me and kissed me before I'd even turned off the light, her hand already sliding down my chest. Her eyes were wide and bright. She was animated.

I was surprised because she almost never initiated, almost never reached for me first, and I kissed her back and pulled her closer and felt how warm she was, how present she was in her body in a way that was very different from usual.

When we had sex and she was more into it than she'd been even the last weekend, more vocal, moving against me instead of just letting me move against her, and when she came she made a sound I'd never heard from her before, something between a gasp and a moan that she tried to muffle against my shoulder, which made it louder.

Afterward she curled up facing away from me and her breathing evened out fast. I lay behind her with my arm around her waist and my mind going around in circles.

I thought about her under the blanket with Marc, about their knees touching or not touching, about the way she'd leaned into his shoulder when she laughed, about the way she'd pulled back like she'd remembered something, like she'd caught herself doing something she shouldn't.

And then I thought about how she'd just been in bed with me, how she'd wanted me, how she'd responded to me, how she'd been more initiating than I could remember her ever being, and I tried to tell myself those two things weren't connected, that I was overthinking it, that she was just getting more comfortable with me, that this was just her opening up the way people do in relationships over time sometimes, to their parter and to their partner's friends.

But I lay awake for a long time, listening to her breathe, feeling the warmth of her body against mine, and the thoughts kept circling back to the same place.

The lean, the shoulder against shoulder, and the way she'd pulled back guiltily. Plus the way she'd reached for me after.

I told myself I was being paranoid, that I was inventing problems that didn't exist, that nothing was going on, that everything was fine.

The next weekend the configuration had already become default without anyone discussing it. When we settled into the living room Saturday night after dinner, Marc sat in the middle section of the sectional and Lila sat next to him and I took the end. It felt like this was just how we sat now, like the geometry had been decided.

Lila quickly pulled the blanket over herself and Marc asked if he could share it the same way he had the week before, except this time it felt less like asking and more like confirming what they'd already established, and she said sure just as automatically and arranged the blanket over both of them while I sat on my end under my own blanket, separate and watching.

The TV was playing some sci-fi movie, something with spaceships and a plot none of us were following, and our conversation came easy and directionless, Marc asking Lila about a paper she'd mentioned working on and her telling him about Virginia Woolf's use of time. I watched and tried not to think about what I couldn't see under the blanket they were sharing.

I was hyperaware of it though, the blanket, what it concealed, the space beneath it where their legs had to be close, had to be almost touching if not for sure touching, and I kept looking at it and then looking away and then looking back, trying to see through the fabric, trying to know what was going on in the space I couldn't access.

We'd been sitting maybe half an hour when something came over Lila's face.

She was mid-sentence, saying something about stream of consciousness, and she stopped talking for just a second, went completely still, and her breath caught in a way that was small but visible, and I knew. Marc's hand had touched her knee under the blanket.

I couldn't see it but I knew it the same way you know it's raining when you hear it against the window, and I watched her face and saw her try to recover, try to pick up the sentence where she'd left off. But there was a flush creeping up her neck, spreading from her collarbone to her jaw, and her voice when she did continue was different, breathier, lighter, less certain.

She didn't move away, though.

That was the thing I kept noticing, the thing that made my heart start pounding hard in my chest. She didn't shift her leg, didn't pull back, didn't

do anything to dislodge whatever contact had just been made. She kept talking, kept trying to act normal, though the flush kept spreading across her skin, making sometime obvious to me, I just didn't know exactly what. But I could tell there was something going on.

Marc was saying something in response to what she'd said, something about narrative perspective, and his face remained completely casual, completely normal, like his hand wasn't under a blanket touching my girlfriend's leg like I knew it was, and Lila nodded along with him and added something, touching his arm to get her word in edgewise. I sat on my end of the couch feeling like I couldn't breathe.

Minutes passed, the conversation continuing around me. I watched Lila's face, watched the way she was trying to control her expression, trying to seem engaged and present in what Marc was saying, even while something else was clearly taking place under the blanket.

At one point the blanket shifted with just a small movement when Marc adjusted his position, and in the gap before it settled again I caught a glimpse.

His hand was on her thigh.

Not her knee, but higher, resting on her thigh casually like it was the most natural thing in the world, his palm flat against her leggings, and then the blanket fell back into place and I couldn't see anymore.

Lila's face was pink now, fully flushed. She was biting her lower lip and I wanted to say something, wanted to ask what was going on, wanted to tell Marc to move his hand off her, but what would I even say?

Don't touch her leg? It sounded insane even in my head, sounded controlling and paranoid, and maybe I was wrong, maybe I hadn't seen what I thought I'd seen, maybe his hand had just been resting near her leg and not on it, and even if it was on her leg, maybe it was just casual friendly contact, maybe I was making it into something it wasn't.

But I could see her face. I could see the flush and the way her breathing had changed and the way she kept glancing down at the blanket like she was aware of what was under it. I knew I wasn't wrong.

The movie ended and another one started automatically, and we kept sitting there, kept talking, Marc's hand remaining where it was under the blanket and Lila remaining flushed. I stayed frozen on my end of the couch, watching and saying nothing.

It was past midnight when we finally went upstairs, and I expected Lila to be quiet and withdrawn, but instead she was keyed up, almost vibrating with energy, and the second we were in my room with the door closed, she was pulling me toward the bed.

She kissed me harder, her hands already working at my shirt, and I was surprised and uncertain, but I kissed her back and let her pull my shirt off, and when we got into bed, she climbed on top of me, which she almost never did, and kissed me while her hips moved against me.

She was different, more eager, more lively, making sounds she usually didn't make, louder and less controlled, and when she came, she didn't try to muffle it, just let her sounds out in the dark room, and I came right after her watching her face above me, flushed and open in a way I'd never seen.

Afterward she collapsed next to me, breathing hard, and curled up against my side, kissing me all over. I put my arm around her and held her and felt thrilled and sick at the same time.

I was thrilled because she'd never been like this with me before, never this open and uninhibited, never this expressive in her body, and I'd wanted this, had wanted her to be less reserved, less guarded, and here she was, finally opening up.

But part of me guessed why.

I knew it was connected to Marc's hand on her thigh, to whatever had happened under that blanket, to the flush that had spread across her skin while another man touched her, and I lay in the dark holding her while she fell asleep and I didn't ask, didn't say anything, just let the knowledge sit heavy in my chest.

I should have said something, of course, I should have asked her what happened downstairs, should have told her I'd seen Marc's hand on her leg, should have asked if she was okay with that, if she wanted that.

But I didn't ask because part of me didn't want to know the answer. Part of me didn't want her to stop being like this, didn't want her to go back to the reserved quiet version of herself that she'd been before. So I lay silent while she slept and told myself I was overthinking it, told myself it was nothing, told myself that tomorrow I'd figure out what to do.

But I already knew I wouldn't do anything. I knew I'd let it continue, knew I'd sit on that couch next weekend and watch it happen again and say nothing because I didn't know how to stop it without losing this, her open and wanting and finally fully engaged with it.

I fell asleep eventually, my arm around her, her breathing slow and even against my chest, and the last thought I had before sleep took me was that I was making a choice by not making a choice, and I didn't know yet what that choice was going to cost.

Lila showed up Friday evening wearing a skirt, which stopped me for a second when I opened the door because she never wore skirts, had always been a jeans or leggings person, but here she was in a denim skirt that hit mid-thigh, shorter than anything I'd seen her wear before, showing her legs in a way that felt calculated.

"Hey," she said, smiling that shy smile, and I said hey back and kissed her and tried not to make a thing of the skirt, tried to act like it was normal, even though it felt significant.

She came inside and set her bag down and we went to the kitchen where I'd already started making dinner. I noticed she was wearing makeup too, not a lot, but more than usual, something around her eyes that made them stand out and something on her lips that made them look darker. I wanted to ask if she was going somewhere after this, if we had plans I'd forgotten about, but I didn't because I knew we didn't have plans, knew the skirt and the makeup were for here, for tonight, and I didn't want to know why.

Marc came back from his usual workout around seven and stopped in the kitchen doorway the same way he always did, but this time when he saw Lila, his eyes went to her legs first, before he looked up to her face and said, "You look really nice, Li."

She blushed immediately, that deep pink that spread from her neck to her cheeks. She said thanks quietly.

"Seriously, you look really good."

She ducked her head and smiled. "Just felt like dressing up, I guess."

I stood at the stove stirring things and watching this.

We ate dinner and moved to the living room and fell into the configuration that had become automatic, Marc in the middle and Lila next to him, me on the end, and she pulled the blanket over herself and Marc without asking.

The movie was something with subtitles that required more attention than any of us were giving it, and the conversation was going on around me, Marc and Lila talking about something, her classes or his, I wasn't tracking it closely enough.

I was watching her face instead, watching her body language, the way she was angled toward Marc, the way her hands were folded in her lap on top of the blanket, everything below hidden.

At some point her breathing changed. Her eyes went wide and were beading on the screen and nobody was talking, but her breath grew shallower, more careful, like she was concentrating on keeping it even. I saw her shift her hips, a small adjustment, and I knew what it could mean even though I couldn't see anything.

Marc's hand was under the blanket. I knew it was probably on her thigh again and probably higher than it had been even last weekend, higher than her knee, higher than her mid-thigh, high enough that with her skirt it had to be touching her bare skin, had to be under the hem even, maybe. I sat watching her face out the corner of my eye and I knew exactly what was taking place even though the blanket hid everything.

My stomach twisted with that sick feeling that was part nausea and part something I didn't want to acknowledge. It both amazed me and appalled me that she would let this take place right in front of me, Lila would, that she would have this in her. And what about Marc, feeling up my girlfriend with me right there in the same room? I tried to convince myself it was all in my head. I had to.

But then I thought about last weekend, about the way she'd been in bed with me after, so much more responsive and open than she'd ever been, and way more willing to try new things, way more willing to let me do things to her body, and I thought about how much I'd liked that version of her, and how much I wanted more of it.

Whatever was happening, I was not in every way mad about it. Being in the same room with her while she was allowing this to be done to her was making me feel things I didn't know about myself. So there was that, too.

I knew it was wrong. I knew I should say something, should tell Marc to move his hand, to knock it off, and should pull Lila away from him and ask her what the hell she was doing. But I also knew that if I did that, she'd likely be ripped apart with embarrassment so bad, she'd go back to being that reserved careful version of herself, and I didn't want that, didn't want to lose this version of her that had been emerging.

So I sat and said nothing and watched her try to keep her breathing normal while my roommate touched her under a blanket three feet away from me.

The conversation continued and Lila was doing her best to participate, to seem engaged and normal, but I could see the flush spreading across her skin, could see the way her eyes kept losing focus for a second before she pulled herself back, and I wondered how far up Marc's hand was now, wondered if he was just touching her thigh or if he'd gone higher, if his fingers were brushing against her underwear, even, and if she was letting him.

I knew she was letting him. It was obvious. She wasn't moving away, she wasn't adjusting her position to dislodge his hand, she wasn't doing anything to stop him, and I sat there knowing that and feeling like I was falling and couldn't find anything to grab onto.

After awhile Lila excused herself to go to the bathroom, and she got up. The blanket fell away and I glanced for evidence of what had been occurring, looking at her skirt to see if it was adjusted or wrinkled in a telling way, but it looked normal and she walked out of the room without looking back at me.

When she was gone Marc adjusted the blanket, pulling it back over himself, and he looked at me.

We made direct eye contact across the sectional through the murky darkness of the room lit only by the show, his face completely calm and casual. Neither of us said anything. The moment lasted for maybe three seconds, maybe five, and then he looked back at the screen and I looked at the show too and we went on sitting in silence until Lila came back.

When she did she sat down next to Marc again but noticeably closer this time, her body angled toward him more than it had been before, The blanket went back over both of them and I watched and said nothing.

The rest of the night continued the same way, Marc's hand back under the blanket, Lila flushed and trying to act normal, me watching from my end and feeling sicker and more aroused with every passing minute.

We went upstairs around one, and the second we were in my room with the door closed, Lila was on me, kissing me hard, her hands pulling at my clothes.

We got into bed and she climbed on top of me and leaned down close to my ear and whispered, "I want to try something." I said okay, my heart pounding, and she told me what she wanted, something we'd never done before, something I'd wanted to try but never thought she'd be comfortable

with, and I was surprised and turned on she wanted it, and I said yes. Of course I said yes.

She crawled slowly backward down over me until she was crouching between my legs, and she lifted me, kissed me, took me in her mouth. “Is that good?” she asked, pushing it around her face and looking up at me.

I could hardly make words, and she chuckled and sank her mouth all the way down.

The whole night was intense and different and she was expressive and completely uninhibited, making sounds and saying things she'd never said before. When we finished we were both breathing hard and covered in sweat and she collapsed next to me and fell asleep almost immediately. It was like no other weekend before it.

I lay next to her in the dark, my arm around her, listening to her breathe, and my mind was going in circles.

What was taking place was so wrong. I knew I should stop it, knew I should talk to her, should I should talk to Marc, knew I should do something other than sit there and watch it happen.

But she'd never been like this with me before. She'd never been so open, so adventurous, so in her own body. She'd always been reserved and careful, tentative, but now she wasn't at all, and I knew why, I knew it was connected to what was going on downstairs with Marc, and I didn't want it to stop.

I wanted her even more like this. I wanted this version of her that was emerging even if it meant watching another man touch her, even if it meant sitting three feet away while his hand was moving up her skirt, even if it meant being complicit in something I knew was crossing all the lines we'd never discussed.

I lay awake for a long time, holding her while she slept, trying to figure out when I'd become, the kind of person who would let this happen, who would choose this, and not finding an answer that made me feel any better about myself.

But I knew what I was going to do. I knew I was going to let it continue. I knew that next weekend I'd sit on that couch again and watch again and say nothing again.

I fell asleep eventually, the choice already made, and hated myself a little bit more for it every day.

Saturday night we ordered pizza and we ate it in the living room, just another weekend night, just the three of us hanging out the way we'd been doing for weeks now.

But I was noticing everything this time, couldn't stop noticing, every small detail cataloging itself in my mind whether I wanted it or not.

I caught the way Lila laughed at Marc's jokes, louder and more genuine than she usually was, a real full-body laugh that made her lean forward and close her eyes, her hand coming up to her mouth, her eyes delighted.

It was the way she was sitting, too, her legs tucked under her in that way girls sit when they're comfortable, her whole body angled toward Marc instead of toward the TV or toward me, oriented in his direction like he was the center of gravity for her in the room.

The makeup she'd put on before coming over was more than last weekend, her eyes darker and her lips pinker and I could tell she'd spent time on it, knew she'd looked in the mirror and made choices about how she wanted to look tonight.

It was a different skirt but still a skirt, and shorter too, showing her legs in a way that felt calculated.

I was on my end of the sectional and they were in the middle, the blanket over both of them again the way it always was now, so I couldn't see anything under it, but I didn't need to see because her face was telling me everything.

One arm under the blanket, Marc's other arm was stretched along the back of the couch behind her, casual and relaxed, and at some point his hand dropped to her shoulder, just to say something to her at first, then to rest there, his fingers on her top, and she leaned into it, her body shifting toward the touch instead of away from it.

I watched that and felt my chest tighten and my hands gripped my own legs.

Maybe I was being paranoid. Maybe physical touch just meant different things to different people. Maybe some people were just more comfortable with casual contact and I was the weird one for being bothered by it. Maybe Marc was just touchy and friendly and it didn't mean anything at all and Lila was just comfortable enough with him now to not be weird about it.

Maybe I was inventing problems that didn't exist, reading meaning into things that were meaningless, turning normal friendly behavior into

something it wasn't because I was insecure or jealous or broken in some way that made me see threats where weren't any.

But I couldn't stop seeing what I was seeing, the way her breathing changed when Marc's hand stayed on her shoulder, got shallower and more controlled like she was concentrating on keeping it even again.

She bit her lower lip when he said something low that I couldn't hear, something just to her, something that made her duck her head and smile to herself, before she darted a glance over at me.

At one point she closed her eyes for several seconds, longer than a blink, and her mouth fell parted and her chest rose and fell in a way that looked like she was trying to steady herself.

Marc's hand was doing something under that blanket, I couldn't see it, but I knew it. I knew his other hand, the one not on her shoulder, was under there touching her, moving on her leg or higher, doing something that was making her breathing change and her face flush and her eyes drop closed. It was dark in the room, but not so dark I couldn't see it.

She was letting him, that was the jaw-dropper. She was sitting there letting the other man touch her while I sat three feet away.

She was opening up sexually and it was because of him, because of what he was doing to her, because of how he was making her feel, and it was making her different with me, making her more adventurous and more uninhibited and more willing.

I sat on my end of the couch watching her face while Marc touched her under the blanket.

I knew that boyfriends didn't let other men touch their girlfriends. I knew that healthy relationships didn't look like this, that I should be angry or hurt or something other than aroused and complicit.

At one point Lila shifted herself and the blanket slipped down a few inches and I could see Marc's hand, could see it resting high on her thigh, his palm on her bare skin where the skirt had been pushed up, before she adjusted the blanket and pulled it back down and the touch disappeared again.

She'd seen me looking, had made eye contact with me for just a second, before covering it back up. But she didn't move his hand, didn't stop what was going on, just hid it again and went back to the conversation like everything was normal.

My heart was pounding and my mouth was dry I felt sick and turned on in equal measure and I hated myself for it but I couldn't stop it.

There was more talking, more laughing, and more of Marc's hand doing things I couldn't see but Lila responding in ways I could see.

It was past midnight and we were still on the couch, the TV playing some late-night talk show now that none of us were watching. Lila and Marc were deep in conversation about something, a story he was telling about his economics professor, and Lila was laughing and shaking her head.

"That can't be real!" she said, still smiling, beaming, at him.

"I swear it's real," Marc said. "He went on for twenty minutes like that."

"I don't believe you!"

"You don't believe?"

"No!" she squealed, laughing, and he leaned in and kissed her.

Just like that. Quick and light, his mouth on hers for maybe a second, and then he pulled back. I sat frozen on my end of the couch with my heart suddenly hammering in my chest so hard I could feel it in my throat. I pretended not to see it, to be focused on the screen.

Lila's eyes went wide, her whole body going still, and she looked at me, the first time she'd looked at me in at least twenty minutes, and I turned back to her unable to move, unable to speak, unable to do anything but sit still while my mind tried to process what had just happened.

Marc was watching both of us, his face completely casual and calm like he'd just done something totally normal, as though kissing someone else's girlfriend was the kind of thing that happened all the time and wasn't worth making a fuss about.

Lila looked back at Marc, her mouth still open, her face already starting to flush, but she didn't say stop.

Didn't say anything. She just looked at him and he looked back at her, and then he leaned in and kissed her again, longer this time, his hand even coming up to her jaw, holding her face, and she kissed him back.

I watched this happen from three feet away.

I watched his mouth on hers, watched the way her eyes fluttered closed, watched his hand on her face the way it tilted her head, and I watched the kiss deepen and last for three seconds, four, five, watched her kiss him back instead of pulling away, watched the whole thing unfold in front of me while I sat completely unable to move or speak or do anything.

When they finally pulled apart, Lila's face was flushed deep red, darker than I'd ever seen it. She looked down at her lap immediately, her hands twisting together. Marc just turned and looked back at the screen like nothing had happened, like he hadn't just kissed my girlfriend right in front of me.

The room fell into complete silence except for the sound of the show, some comedian talking about something I couldn't hear because there was a roaring in my ears. None of us said anything, none of us moved, and the silence stretched out and filled the room.

My heart was pounding so hard I thought they could hear it. My hands were gripping my knees, my nails digging into my skin, and my mouth hung open because I was trying to breathe normally and couldn't manage to.

I knew I should have told Marc to get the fuck out. I should have asked Lila what the fuck she thought she was doing. I should have done something other than sit there in silence like. But I didn't say anything. I didn't move.

Five minutes passed, maybe more, the only sound being the show and our breathing, before then Marc said something about the show we were supposedly watching, some casual observation. Lila responded, her voice quiet and shaky, but just like that the conversation started again, picking up some different topic, moving forward like the kiss hadn't occurred.

I sat listening to them talk and couldn't process any of it, couldn't follow what they were saying, could only replay the kiss over and over in my mind, the way he'd leaned in, the way she'd let him, the way she'd kissed him back.

We stayed up another hour, the conversation flowing, Marc and Lila talking and occasionally asking me something and me responding with words I didn't hear, and the whole time I felt like I was underwater, like I was watching this happen from somewhere far away.

When we finally went upstairs Lila walked ahead of me, fast, not looking back, and when we got to my room she closed the door and stood with her back to me for a long moment.

I thought she was going to say something about the kiss, thought she was going to explain or apologize, but she didn't say anything, she just started pulling off her clothes without looking at me, and when she got into bed she still wouldn't make eye contact.

But then she reached for me, pulled me toward her, kissed me hard, desperately, her hands already moving down my body, and I was so confused and so turned on and so fucked up about all of it that I just went with it, kissed her back, let her pull me up to her, let her take me in her mouth.

She drove my hand down between her legs, singled out my finger, rubbed herself with my fingertip until I got the idea, and then she made me push two fingers deep inside her.

She writhed on my fingers, bit on my neck, pushed her hips up and shove my hand down harder between her legs. She rubbed herself on me with a trembling madness.

She'd never let me touch her there before.

When I climbed over her and entered her, she was more passionate than she'd ever been, almost frantic about it, her nails digging into my back, her hips moving hard against mine, and making sounds I'd never heard from her, loud and uncontrolled, saying my name and saying please and don't stop.

I came harder than ever, my whole body shaking with it, and she came right after, her back arching off the bed, crying out, and we both collapsed breathing hard and she turned onto her side facing away from me and her breathing evened out almost immediately, falling asleep like someone who'd just resolved something instead of someone who'd just betrayed her boyfriend.

I lay next to her in the dark, my body humming from what we'd just done, and my mind trying to make sense of it.

She'd she'd let him kiss her and had kissed him back right in front of me. And then she rushed upstairs and fucked me like that, like she was desperate for it, like she needed it. I didn't know what it meant, didn't know if it was guilt or arousal or some fucked up combination of both.

I thought about the kiss, replayed it frame by frame in my mind, the way he'd leaned in so casually, the way she'd frozen and then melted into it. I replaced the way her eyes closed.

She hadn't just let it happen, she hadn't just frozen and waited for it to be over. She'd participated in it, she kissed him back, she wanted it.

And then she fucked me like she'd never fucked me before, passionate and desperate and completely unhinged, and I loved it, I came so hard I saw stars, and I lay there knowing it was connected, knowing her kissing Marc

had led directly to her fucking me like that, I knew his touching her did it, and I didn't know what to do with that information.

I only felt aroused and confused and already wondering what would happen next weekend, if it would happen again, if she would let him kiss her, if I would sit and watch and let it happen again.

Saturday night we were in the living room, Lila deciding to stay all day, nobody wanting the weekend to end. I thought maybe Friday night had been an aberration, a one-time thing that happened because of too much time together, or it was too late at night or something. But within the first twenty minutes of settling down I realized the first kiss hadn't been an ending, it had only been an opening.

Marc came in and leaned over and kissed her as he settled down to sitting beside her to watch a show. There was no buildup this time, no conversation leading to it, just a casual lean-in with his mouth on hers, quick and light, and he pulled back and started watching the screen like it was nothing, like this was just something that happened now.

Lila blushed the same way she had the night before, her whole face and neck flushing. But she didn't say anything, she didn't pull away, she just ducked her head and bit her lip and after a moment went back to watching the show too. She flicked the blanket and this time made sure to tuck it around both of their legs and pulled it up high on their chests.

I sat on my end of the couch and watched and felt my stomach drop because I fully understood what I was seeing now. The first kiss had changed the rules. It had opened a door that was propped open now. This was just how things were going to be from now on.

Twenty minutes later, in a lull in their quiet and private conversation, the room so dark it was hard to see, music on with the show at the same time, Marc kissed her again, longer this time, his hand coming up to the side of her face. She turned to him and kissed him back, her eyes closing softly, and I watched from three feet away unable to look away and unable to make myself say anything. They kissed for a minute or more, mouths all over each other. It was as though a part of their conversation, the way they both seamlessly fell into it. It was like just something they did now.

Under the blanket Marc's hand was surely on her thigh, high up where it had been before, and when he kissed her I saw Lila's legs shift, saw her part them a little, making room for him, and my heart began pounding and my mouth ran dry. I felt paralyzed from the neck down.

Marc pulled back from the kiss finally and they went back to watching the show, both their heads leaning back against the cushions together, they were both so slumped down in the couch. His hand was still under the blanket, still on her thigh, and the show played on and nobody said anything about what was going on.

Every now and then, Marc would lean over and kiss her more, sometimes quick, sometimes longer, and every time Lila would blush, but every time she would be receptive to him, or even kiss him back, and every time I would sit there watching and saying nothing. Watching the show, I saw her eyes wide and bright, but I knew she was seeing nothing. As soon as he budged, she turned to him, closed her eyes, tilted her head back, and parted her lips for him. Her hand came up and ran around the back of his neck, tugged on his hair, curled around his ear. Her back came up off the couch and she rolled on her hips toward him. Then they would both settle back and pretend nothing.

At one point Marc pulled Lila closer to him, his arm going fully around her shoulders, pulling her harder against his side, and when he kissed her, his other hand, the one under the blanket, did something to her that made her gasp into his mouth, a small sharp intake of breath that turned into a quiet sound escaping her throat.

I couldn't see what his hand was doing of course, the blanket hid everything. But I could see her face, could see the way her eyes closed and her mouth opened and her whole body tensed and then relaxed. I could see the flush spreading down her neck, could hear the small sounds she was making now, the little gasps and sighs that she was trying to keep quiet but couldn't quite suppress.

This went on for over an hour, kissing and touching under the blanket, Lila getting more and more flushed and breathless, her body responding to whatever Marc was doing under that blanket, and I sat watching the whole thing, frozen, unable to leave, unable to speak, unable to do anything but witness.

Around one in the morning Marc finally pulled his arm away from Lila and said he was tired and going to bed. He stood up and stretched and said goodnight to both of us like it was a completely normal evening, like he hadn't just spent the last hour making out with my girlfriend and touching her under a blanket.

When he was gone Lila sat for a moment not looking at me, her face still flushed, her breathing still uneven, before she stood up fast and headed for the stairs without saying anything.

I followed her up to my room. She was already naked by the time I closed the door, and the second I was close enough, she grabbed me and pulled me toward the bed, kissing me hard, desperate.

She pushed me onto my back and climbed on top of me, which she had never done before, had never initiated like this, and she positioned herself over me and slid down onto me and started moving. She was thoroughly wet, she was completely ready. Normally I take my time with her, work her up to it. Not this time. She didn't need foreplay.

She rode me hard, her hands braced on my chest, her head thrown back, making sounds I'd never heard from her, loud and uninhibited, moaning and gasping and saying "oh god" and "don't stop" and "Connor please!" I watched her above me, watched her body move, watched her face twist in pleasure, and I knew I'd never seen her like this, so completely lost to it.

It was the best sex we ever had.

She came first, crying out, her whole body shaking, and I came right after, my hands gripping her hips, pulling her down onto me as hard as I could, and we both collapsed afterward breathing like we'd been running.

She rolled off me and curled up on her side facing away from me, and I lay trying to catch my breath and waiting for her to say something, to explain, to acknowledge what had happened downstairs or what had just happened here.

But she just lay with her back to me, her breathing gradually slowing, and after a few minutes I realized she was asleep. She wasn't going to talk about it.

"Lila," I said quietly.

She didn't respond, and I lay staring at her back and didn't say anything else.

I realized over the past few weeks that I would rather watch her kiss another man than go back to the way things were before between us in bed.

I was making that choice consciously now. I was choosing to let it continue because of what I got out of it. I was trading her fidelity for her passion and deciding that was a trade I was willing to make.

I hated myself for it, but I couldn't deny it. Plus, watching her with him, it was infecting me.

I fell asleep eventually and dreamed about things taking place under blankets that I couldn't see, and woke up hard and ashamed and knowing that next weekend would be the same, and the weekend after that, and I would keep letting it happen because I'd already decided what mattered more.

Saturday night Lila came over dressed in a tight dress I never saw before, make-up pink and frosted, her eyes lined and dark. She was basically in Marc's lap from the moment she dragged him into the room, not even pretending there was distance between them anymore. She sat sideways across his thigh and and draped the blanket over both of them, her body curving into his. I sat on my end of the sectional watching this new configuration knowing we'd crossed into something different.

They began kissing all the time, every few minutes during their talking and laughing together, sometimes quick and sometimes long and deep, and nobody was even pretending to watch the TV anymore, the movie playing to an audience of none, the volume off, some deep bass music playing on top of it.

Her body would tense and her eyes would close and her mouth would fall open, and then she'd kiss him all over again, moan inside the kiss, or just look at him silently with some deep seriousness, before her eyes fluttered.

We all tried to make the effort once in a while to carry on some kind of conversation, but we all knew the conversation, like the show, was beside the point.

I watched Marc's hands move on her, one arm around her back holding her against him, and I watched Lila's arms hang around his neck. I saw her gasp, startled, and her hand squeeze his hair. I watched them kiss and pull apart and kiss again and laugh privately. I saw her head throw back before they took a moment to check in with the show enough to maintain the pretense, and my heart was hammering and my hands were shaking. I couldn't make myself look away.

Her whole body seemed to be in motion like a wave flowing through her. She rocked her forehead on his and glanced over at me. She whispered in his ear and suddenly her body went stiff and she bit his ear and moaned in his neck. She lightly slapped his cheek as though to warn him, but she also smiled and sucked on his tongue when he stuck it out at her.

I pretended to watch the show. They stared at each other with their eyes wide open, an inch apart, as her jaw dropped down, her breath stopped, and her body jerked. He touched her lips with his thumb and she instinctively sank her mouth down over it. Her back swayed and she glared at him with frustration mounting on her face.

At some point the blanket slipped down a few inches without them aware, the fabric shifting when Lila moved on him, and suddenly I could see what had been hidden.

Marc's hand was up her skirt and between her legs. Lila's legs were parted, making room for his hand. I could see his fingers moving, could see the motion of them working between her thighs, and my brain stuttered trying to process what I was seeing.

Lila's eyes opened and she saw me looking, saw that I could see, and we made direct eye contact for maybe two seconds, but she didn't stop it, didn't push his hand away, didn't close her legs.

She just reached down and pulled the blanket back up, covering herself again, and started kissing Marc like nothing had happened. She whispered in his ear and laughed.

I sat with my hands gripping in fists so hard my knuckles went white, my whole body rigid. I'd seen it, another man's hand between my girlfriend's legs, had seen her letting him touch her like that, and I couldn't breathe, couldn't think, couldn't do anything but sit while my heart nearly pounded its way out of my chest.

Five minutes later the blanket slipped again and I could see Marc's other hand now, the one that had been around her back, but was now inside her dress and on her bare skin, moving up her side, and I watched the shape of it under the fabric, watched it slide higher, watched it reach her chest and cup her breast through her bra.

Lila made a small sound, a quiet gasp, and her back arched, pressing into his touch. I was watching this happen, was watching another man touch my girlfriend's breasts while she sat in his lap and let him.

I sat frozen, unable to move. I was painfully hard, too, straining against my jeans, and I hated myself for it but I couldn't deny it, couldn't make it go away.

At one point the blanket fell away completely, slipped off them onto the floor, and for maybe thirty seconds everything became visible.

Lila's dress was pushed up, Marc's hand was on her breast under her bra, squeezing her, and his other hand was between her legs under her skirt. Lila was grinding against his hand, her hips moving in small circles, and they were making out, too, mouths open and desperate on each other, I could see all of it, every detail. They didn't even know the blanket fell.

I watched for thirty seconds, forty-five, and couldn't look away. Lila's eyes opened and she saw me watching and she pulled back from the kiss finally and reached down to grab the blanket from the floor and she yanked it back over them, covering everything again. But she didn't stop, didn't get off his lap, she just kept going with the blanket hiding it now.

I sat shaking, my breath coming fast and shallow, my cock so hard it hurt.

They kept going for another hour, kissing and touching under the blanket, and I could see Lila's face, could see her getting more and more flushed and breathless, could see her grinding on Marc's lap, could hear the small sounds she was making. I sat watching and hating myself and so turned on I felt like I might come in my pants.

Marc made Lila stop, though she clung to him and said no. He laughed and kissed her and slipped out from under her, but she grasped at him. He got away from her clinging fingers and looked down at me as he passed on his way up to bed with a look as though to say "Whew, she's a hot one." He even slapped me on the shoulder in passing.

Lila lay slumped in the corner of the couch and made a show of pouting with her arms crossed over her chest.

When we finally got upstairs, she kissing me frantically, pulling at my clothes, and we fell onto the bed. When I touched her breast she moaned and arched hard. Marc had been touching her there, had been making her feel this, and now I was touching her where he had touched.

"Fuck me," she said, breathless and desperate. "Please, Connor, I need you to fuck me right now!"

It was not Lila anymore. She gobbled me up and if I didn't stop her, she would have pumped me dry into her mouth with both hand and mouth at the same time.

She told me what she wanted for the first time ever, told me to be rougher, too, to scratch her back, to pull her hair, and so I did, I did everything she asked, and I fucked her as hard as I could, she told me not to worry, she wasn't going to break, she laughed, and she was screaming loud

enough that Marc could definitely hear her through the thin walls. But I didn't care, I wanted him to hear. So did she, it was clear.

She came twice on me, her whole body convulsing, and I came so hard I nearly passed out, my hands in her hair pulling her head back, my nails dragging down her back the way she'd asked, me slamming her doggy style and filling the room with the slapping sound, and his room too. Afterward we both collapsed sweating and gasping.

I lay next to her in the dark, my heart still racing, my body still humming, and I saw again what I'd seen downstairs, Marc's hand between her legs, her hips grinding on him, the way she'd looked at me and just covered herself back up and kept going.

I thought about the way she'd just begged me to fuck her, about the way she'd screamed, about how she'd never wanted me like this before, had never been this desperate for me, this uninhibited.

She'd let another man finger her and it had made her so turned on she dragged my upstairs and fucked me like she was starving for it. It was completely fucked up, but I'd never felt her want me like that before and I couldn't bring myself to stop it.

I lay in the dark next to her and I knew I wasn't going to end it, wasn't going to confront her, wasn't going to throw Marc out. I was going to let it keep going, I was going to let another man finger my girlfriend and squeeze her tits and make out with her because it made her want me more.

I kept thinking about next weekend, about what would happen next, about how far this would go, all the while knowing I was going to let it go as far as it went because I couldn't make myself choose differently.

Friday night there wasn't even a pretense anymore, no more hiding or pretending we were watching a show, just Lila on Marc's lap from the beginning, straddling him, facing him, her legs down either side of his hips and her arms hung around his neck. They were seriously making out before I'd even sat down.

I took my spot on the other end of the sectional and watched them, watched Lila's body press against Marc's, watched their mouths moving together, watched his hands slid over her hips and her back. The blanket that had been covering them for weeks was on the floor already, forgotten, nobody bothering to maintain even that thin illusion of concealment.

They kissed for maybe ten minutes, deep and hungry, Lila's hands in Marc's hair and his hands sliding up and down her back, before Marc pulled

back and grabbed the hem of Lila's top and started pulling it up.

She lifted her arms automatically, helping him, letting him pull her top over her head, and then she was sitting on his lap in just her bra and her skirt, her pale skin visible in the dim light from the one lamp in the corner, and I sat watching my girlfriend let another man undress her in my living room.

Marc's hands went immediately to her bare skin, sliding over her sides, her stomach, her back, touching her everywhere. He leaned in and kissed her neck, her collarbone, the top of her chest above her bra, and Lila's eyes were closed and her head was tipped back and she was making small quiet sounds.

I was so hard it hurt, my cock straining against my jeans. I hated that I was sitting there watching and getting turned on instead of being angry, instead of stopping it, but I couldn't stop watching and couldn't make my arousal go away.

Marc's hand slid up her back to her bra clasp and I saw Lila tense, saw her body go still for just a second, before Marc paused with his hand on the clasp and pulled back to look at her.

He didn't say anything, he just looked at her, the question silent and clear, and Lila opened her eyes and looked back at him and hesitated, but she nodded.

It was almost imperceptible, but she nodded, and Marc unhooked her bra and pulled it forward off her shoulders and down her arms, and then my girlfriend was topless on the man's lap, her breasts bare, and I was sitting six feet away watching, music louder now, deep bass beating, only the light of some show on the screen lighting up my girlfriend's body.

Marc dropped the bra over the back of the couch and his hands went immediately to her breasts, cupping them, squeezing them, and Lila gasped and arched into his touch. Then his mouth was on her, kissing and sucking her nipples, and she moaned loud, her hands gripping his shoulders.

I sat frozen, unable to move, unable to look away, watching another man's mouth on my girlfriend's breast, watching her respond to it, watching her grind on his lap while he sucked her nipples, and I was so hard and so sick and so unable to process it that I sat in a kind of suspended horror.

This went on for a long time, Marc rubbing her breasts, sucking them, biting them, and Lila grinding in his lap and making sounds and completely lost in it, her head rolling back and her body moving on him.

Marc looked over at me. It was direct eye contact across the dim living room, his face still in Lila's bare chest, his hand cupping her breast, and he pulled back and said, "This okay, man?"

His voice was quiet and casual, like he was asking if I minded if he changed the channel. My mouth opened and I tried to speak, tried to say no, tried to say stop, tried to say anything, but nothing came out. Just silence, just my mouth open and no words, my whole body shaking. It was the first time he acknowledged me at all the whole time.

He looked at me for another few seconds, waiting, and when I didn't say anything, he took it as yes, took my silence as consent, and he went back to my girlfriend, went back to kissing her breasts. Lila's eyes opened for a second and she looked at me too, and I saw something in her face, something like guilt or shame or maybe just acknowledgment, too, and then her eyes closed again and she ground down harder into his lap.

It was beyond surreal. They kept going for maybe another twenty minutes, Marc touching her and Lila grinding on him, both of them breathing hard, me watching and hating myself and so turned on I thought I might come without even touching.

Eventually they stopped, Marc pulling back and Lila sliding off his lap. She picked up her bra and her top from the floor and put them back on, her hands shaking, her face flushed dark red, and nobody saying anything.

Marc stood up and stretched and said he was going to bed, said goodnight like this was completely normal, and headed upstairs. Lila stood for a moment not looking at me before she went upstairs too, and I followed after a minute, my legs unsteady up the steps.

In my room Lila said "Fuck me" against my mouth. "Hard. Now."

We fell onto the bed and she was insatiable, begging, telling me exactly what she wanted, how hard, how rough. I gave her everything she asked for, fucked her as hard as I could. She came screaming, her nails digging into my back, and then came again a few minutes later, her whole body shaking.

When I came, every muscle in my body tensed, and afterward I collapsed on top of her and we both lay gasping. It was over in five frantic and energized minutes.

She fell asleep almost immediately, the way she'd been doing, just rolling over and dropping into sleep instantly. I thought about her topless on Marc's lap, about his mouth on her nipples, about the way she'd moaned, about the way she'd looked at me and kept going.

I thought about Marc asking me if it was okay, about my silence, about how my silence had been license, had been complicity, had been me choosing to let him do it to her.

And I thought about how she'd rushed up stairs to fuck me afterward, how desperate and hungry she'd been, how she'd never wanted me like that before any of this started.

The next night they didn't even turn a show on, just got a playlist on.

I came downstairs from my room around ten to find Lila and Marc already on the couch, already kissing, making out and grinding each other, and I stood for a moment in the doorway before I went to the armchair on the other side of the coffee table. I couldn't sit on the sectional next to them anymore, I couldn't be that close.

Marc already had Lila's top off by the time I sat down, her bra coming off seconds later, and then his hands were on the waistband of her skirt and he was pulling it down. She was lifting her hips to help him and I watched her skirt come off and then her underwear, I watched him strip her completely naked while she sat on his lap in our living room.

Her pale skin glowed in the dim light. Marc was still dressed, but his jeans were unzipped, and I could see his cock sticking out, could see him pull it out further, could see it fully hard, noticeably bigger than mine, and I watched Lila's hand wrap around it, watched her stroke him, watched her gasp looking down at it.

Marc's hand went between her legs and I heard the sound of it, wet and obscene, heard his fingers slide into her, and Lila moan loud and unrestrained, nothing shy about her anymore, nothing reserved.

"Don't stop," she said, breathless, grinding against his hand. "Please don't stop." She rose and fell on her knees over his lap, pumping his cock in both her hands, feeling it with her fingertips, scratching him with her nails.

I sat in the chair six feet away watching my naked girlfriend beg another man to finger her, watching her stroke his cock, and I couldn't move, I couldn't speak, I could barely breathe.

Marc worked his fingers inside her, his other hand on her breasts, and Lila was moaning continuously now, high tone and breathless, her hips moving constantly, chasing his touch, and I could hear how wet she was, could hear the sounds his fingers made moving in and out of her.

Her whole body went rigid and then shook, and she cried out. Marc kept his fingers moving through it, drawing her out, and when she finally went

limp against him he pulled his hand away and I saw how wet his fingers were.

"You should see how wet she is, man," Marc said quietly over to me, looking at me, holding up his hand so I could see. Lila made a small whimpering sound but didn't protest, didn't cover herself. She hid her face and grinned into his shoulder. She reached up and pulled his hand down from where he was rotating it to show me just how wet she was. But only to push it back down under her.

I stared at his wet fingers and couldn't process what I was seeing, what was occurring, what I was allowing to happen.

Marc brought his fingers back between her legs and started on her again. Lila was still sensitive, began gasping and squirming again, and he worked her slowly, building her back up, and I watched her get close again, watched her body tense and her breathing get ragged, and then he stopped.

He pulled his hand away completely, and Lila made a desperate sound, almost a sob.

"Not yet," Marc said quietly, and she whimpered against his mouth.

He did this over and over, bringing her to the edge and then stopping, making her beg, making her wait, completely in control of her while she fell apart in his lap, desperate and pleading, squeezing and pulling on his cock frantically.

"Please," she kept saying. "Please, Marc, please."

Hearing her say his name like that, begging him, made something twist in my chest, something painful and sharp, but I was so hard I couldn't think, couldn't do anything but sit and watch.

Marc finally let her come again after maybe twenty minutes of edging her, his fingers working fast inside her, and she came so hard she was crying, tears running down her face, her body convulsing. The sounds she made were almost sobs. "You're so mean to me!" she whimpered into his hair.

He let her recover for a minute, holding her, stroking her back, and then he started again. She was so sensitive now that she was shaking, begging him to stop or to keep going, I couldn't tell which, and he brought her to one more orgasm that left her completely wrecked, collapsed against him, crying and gasping.

Marc then pushed her back into the cushions, swung himself over her body, and knelt over her hips. He rubbed her lips with his thumb and her

mouth fell open, then sucked deeply on it. Almost as though she wouldn't notice, he withdrew his thumb and pushed the head of his cock against her lips. She opened for him and tilted her head back.

She held his balls and he knelt over her chest and fucked her mouth. Then Lila curled her finger and thumb hard around the base of him and now it was Marc's turn to lose control. When he tried to pull back, she reached with her other hand to grip his ass and keep him inside her.

He groaned soon, and I saw his cum ooze from the corners of her mouth even as he continued to trust himself in her mouth. When he pulled out of her, he used his t-shirt to wipe her mouth.

"You okay?" he asked her quietly, and she finally nodded. I sat in the chair watching this intimacy between them and felt like I was drowning.

He stood up and tucked himself back into his jeans and zipped them, and said goodnight and headed upstairs to his room. Lila remained on the couch for a long moment not moving, not looking at me.

Then she stood up and walked past me toward the stairs and I followed her up to my room.

She wouldn't look at me when we got inside, she just started pulling my clothes off, and she pulled me to the bed, pulled me on top of her, pushed her legs up and dropped them wide, wrapped them around me.

"Fuck me," she whispered. "Fuck me hard and good."

I pushed into her. She was wetter than I'd ever felt her, and she came almost immediately, her back arching and her voice breaking on a cry. I knew she'd been on edge all night, had been kept right there by Marc and was still so desperate.

I kept going and she kept coming, or maybe it was one long continuous orgasm, I couldn't tell, her body shaking and her voice breaking and her nails digging into my back, and when I finally came she was trembling beneath me.

I rolled off her and lay staring at the ceiling while my heart slowly stopped racing.

I thought about Marc's fingers inside her, about the wet sounds, about her begging him, about the way she'd cried when she came.

I thought about her saying his name, Please, Marc, please. I thought about how he'd kissed her forehead after, how there was an intimacy between them now that went beyond just physical, something gentle and protective that made it worse.

Tomorrow I would tell Marc to stay away from her, would end this before it went any further. She'd come the second I pushed into her because Marc had spent an hour working her up, edging her, making her desperate, and then I got to be the one she fucked, got to be the one inside her when she finally got the release she'd been begging for.

That's what I was allowing, that's what I'd become, someone who sat in a chair and watched another man finger his girlfriend to tears and then fucked her after, and called it a relationship.

I fell asleep hating myself.

When I woke up the next morning Lila was already awake, already dressed, and she kissed me goodbye and said she'd see me next weekend. I said okay, neither of us mentioning what happened.

Lila arrived the next Friday evening and I could tell the second she walked through the door that she knew that tonight was different, that something had been decided without anyone saying it.

She was wearing something I'd never seen before, something that looked new, a short, body-hugingly tight dress, and her makeup was done carefully, her hair down and loose and waved, and when she kissed me hello, her hands were already shaking.

We didn't eat dinner, didn't watch a movie, didn't pretend this was going to be a normal Friday night. We existed in the house in a state of waiting, and by nine, we were in the living room, Marc and Lila on the couch and me in the chair, and nobody said a word about what was going to happen, but we all knew.

Lila's clothes came off fast, Marc pulling her dress over her head and her bra off and her underwear down, and then he was undressing too, pulling his shirt off and standing to take off his jeans and his boxers, and I watched Lila watch him undress.

Her eyes went to his cock immediately. I could see her looking, could see her taking in his size, and I could see it too, could see that he was bigger than me, thicker and longer than I was. I watched Lila stare at it and I saw something in her face, something like nervousness or anticipation or both.

Marc laid her down on the couch, her back against the cushions. He laid down between her legs, hooked her knees over his shoulders, and kissed her all over her thighs and stomach.

I shivered. Something in the way she pushed her fingers through his hair, the way she opened her legs and rolled her head back, it was almost as

if it wasn't the first time. I knew, or thought I knew, that she'd never been given that before. She was sure, she told me, she wouldn't like it, she found it too embarrassing. She never let me and I never pushed it.

Yet here she was, not even hesitating to let this man have all of her. He licked her there and she gasped and arched and lifted her hips off the couch. She pulled her knees up and ground her hips into his mouth and sucked breath through gritted teeth.

Her orgasm came fast, rippling through her, she crying as loud as she ever did with me up in my room. And when it subsided, she laughed at herself, mussed his hair with her hand, and draped her arm over her mouth as though shy suddenly.

But he gave her no respite. He crawled up over her, kissed her, she returning it with passion, lifting herself up to him to chase the kiss, before he positioned himself between her legs, kneeling on the couch, his cock hard and ready in his hand, and then he looked over at me.

There was direct eye contact across the dim living room, him naked between my girlfriend's spread legs, when he said, "You good, bro?"

Lila dug her fingers into his sides, hooked her heels into his back, smiled up at him, lifted her hips up to his hips, writhed with impatience under him. "Baby..." she whispered with urgency. Her head rolled side to side.

My mouth opened. I tried to speak, tried to say no, tried to say stop, tried to say anything, but nothing came out, just silence, just my mouth open and my throat closed with no words.

Marc waited maybe three seconds watching me, and when I didn't say anything, he understood it as yes, took my silence as approval the way he'd been doing for weeks now.

He looked back at Lila and positioned his cock at her pussy, rubbed the head against her slit. She was so wet for him, I could see it glistening, could see evidence of how ready she was for him.

He teased her and she laughed and cried and moaned and seethed at him. She lifted her hips and chased his cock with her pussy, and he snickered down at her.

"Marc!" she growled at him. "I'm not joking!"

Then he pushed himself inside her and her head rolled back, her eyes rolled up, and her chest arched high. .

Slowly, inch by inch, and I watched Lila's face, watched her mouth fall open and her eyes close and her back arch so deep, watched her take another man's cock inside her, watched her pussy stretch around him.

She made a sound I'd never heard from her, low and broken, something between a moan and a gasp. Marc kept pushing until he was fully inside her, buried completely in her, and he held himself still for a moment.

"Fuck," Lila breathed out hard, her hands gripping the couch cushions. "Oh fuck, Marc! Just like that baby!"

He started moving, started pulling almost all the way out and pushing deeply back in, slow long strokes. Lila moaned loudly with each thrust, her whole body moving with the force of him fucking her.

"Yeah!" she groaned loud and long.

I sat in the chair watching him fuck my girlfriend, watching his cock slide in and out of her, watching her face twist in pleasure, watching her breasts bounce with each thrust. I was so hard it hurt and so sick I thought I might throw up but so unable to look away that I couldn't even blink.

Marc picked up speed, thrusting into her harder. Lila's moans got louder, less controlled. She was saying things now, saying yes and please and oh god and don't stop, begging him the same way she'd begged him before, completely lost to it.

He fucked her hard like that for maybe ten minutes, missionary, me watching her face the whole time, watching her come undone, watching her be fucked by someone else, and then he pulled out.

Lila made a moan of protest, but Marc was already flipping her over, manhandling her onto her hands and knees, yanking her ass in the air facing him, and he pushed back inside her from behind in one hard thrust, and Lila cried out.

He fucked her from behind, his hands pulling on her hips back onto his cock with each thrust, the sound of skin slapping against skin filling the room. I could see everything from this angle, could see his cock pistoning in and out of her pussy, could see how her pussy stretched around him, could see her whole body rocking with the force of it.

She was almost screaming now, loud and uninhibited, and at some point Marc pulled her up so she was still on her knees but upright, so she was facing me now, facing the chair where I sat, and our eyes met.

We made direct eye contact while another man fucked her from behind, while his cock was buried deep inside her, and her face was twisted with

pleasure, his hands around her tits squeezing her, she completely transformed from the shy reserved girl she'd been, that one who was gone entirely now, so that there was something in her eyes I couldn't read, something between shame and defiance and pure overwhelmed ecstasy.

She held my gaze while Marc jolted her body, and she moaned and gasped, and I couldn't look away, couldn't break eye contact with her, watched her face while another man used her body.

Then her glassy eyes rolled back and her whole body started shaking and she came, her pussy clenching around Marc's cock, her moans turning to something closer to sobs. Marc didn't stop, he kept fucking her through it, kept his hands on her tits holding her in place.

It struck me all at once then. It was the way they moved together, the way they understood what they wanted, the way he fucked her so hard, something I only just learned that she liked, the way they kissed while they fucked, held each other's gaze. How could it be their first time? They fit together too well.

He lasted maybe another five minutes before his rhythm got erratic, his movements less controlled, and then he was coming, pushing deeper inside her one last time.

He tried to pull out, but my girlfriend, she reached around behind herself, dug her nails into his thighs, and she said, "Inside me this time, baby."

I could see him pulsing, could see the moment he came inside her, filling her, and I stared at their point of ultimate contact stunned.

He stayed inside her for a moment longer, both of them breathing hard, and then he pulled out slowly and I could see his cum run from her pussy, could see evidence of what had just happened leaking out of my girlfriend and onto my couch.

Marc stood up and started pulling on his boxers and jeans like he'd just finished any normal activity. Lila remained on the couch on her hands and knees for a moment before collapsing onto her side, her body still trembling.

Marc pulled his shirt on and came over to where Lila was still lying and leaned down and kissed her forehead, gentle and tender.

"Night, Lil Lila," he said softly with a smirk, and she made a small sound in response, a smile, and then he straightened up and headed for the

stairs, glancing at me once as he left with just a brief look as though checking if I caught that, and then he was gone.

The door to his room closed upstairs and the house fell into silence.

Lila was still on the couch, naked, her legs still spread, his cum dripping between her thighs and onto the cushions, her body flushed and marked, and she looked at me and I looked at her.

She opened her mouth like she was going to say something, but nothing came out, and she closed it again, but we kept staring at each other.

Finally she sat up slowly, wincing, and started gathering her clothes from where they were scattered on the floor. She walked past me to the stairs.

I stayed in the chair and didn't follow, didn't know if I was supposed to follow, and I heard her footsteps on the stairs and then the sound of a bedroom door opening and closing.

I sat alone in the living room in the dim light from the one lamp, the house completely silent around me now, and I couldn't move.

I could smell the sex in the air, could see the wet spot on the couch where it happened, could still see Lila's face in my mind, the way she'd looked at him with familiarity while Marc fucked her, and the way she'd looked at me, checking.

Eventually I stood up, my legs unsteady, and I went upstairs to my room because where else would I go.

I was surprised and I wasn't, when I opened my bedroom door and didn't find her in my bed. Too mentally exhausted to think that through, to make sense of it, though there was nothing I didn't know now, I crashed out instantly as my head hit the pillow.

It was an hour or two later that I was woken up to the sound of a steady rhythmic banging on the wall behind my head. I sat up and listened harder.

I heard high pitched crying then, gasping and moaning. It was Lila's voice. Marc was fucking her or she was fucking him, whichever it was, it was rough and hard and thorough.

It went on like that, stopping for awhile, some murmuring and hushed laughing, and then it would start up again, her crying louder, the thumps on the wall heavy and fast. I was thankful when it finally stopped. Before I fell asleep I determined that this time, for sure, I would have to tell her, that was too much, it was over.

I wanted to sneak out in the morning before I had to see her or Marc. But I found them already up in the kitchen. Lila was wearing one of Marc's long t-shirts.

"Jason said he's moving out," was the first thing she said to me.

"He's moving in with his girlfriend," Marc said. He pulled on Lila until her back came to his chest, and he wrapped his arms around her from behind and leaned down to kiss her neck even while she stared at me with a grin. "We're going to need a new roomy," he said to me.

"And you already know me," Lila said. "We already cook so well together, too, don't we."

"She hates her place," Marc said, and he turned her around. She lifted herself on her toes, wrapped her arms around his neck, and when he pulled her up to kiss her, his shirt rode up her back showing me she had nothing on below.

"I don't hate it," she said, coming back down. She turned in his arms but pushed her hands behind her back, down low. Marc startled and grimaced and she snickered. "I just really like it here a lot more."

"You want to move in here?" I said.

"I can take Jason's room."

"Here, in this house?"

She stepped out of Marc's embrace, pushed his hands from her body, and stepped over toward me. With her eyes on mine, she raised herself on her toes, draped her arms around my neck, pushed her body into mine. She took my wrist in her hand and pushed my hand down between her legs, separated my finger out, drew it over her pussy, down inside her folds. She was soaking and boiling hot.

"We could make it work," she said softly, and she buried her tongue deep into my mouth.

I looked over her head to Marc, who only smirked and turned to the coffee machine to make another cup.

"You know you love watching," she murmured in my ear, and she chuckled and reached down between my legs.

Of course she found me raging hard.